

PHILOSOPHY

What Is Knowledge and How Do We Get It?

An Introduction to Epistemology

*Based on Matthias Steup and Ram Neta, 'Epistemology',
Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Fall 2025 Edition)*

Lower Sixth & Upper Sixth Philosophy | Pre-Reading Resource

Introduction: What Is Epistemology?

Guiding Question: *What does it mean to know something — and why should philosophers care?*

The word 'epistemology' derives from the Greek *episteme* (knowledge or understanding) and *logos* (reason or account). Epistemology is, quite simply, the philosophical study of knowledge: what it is, how we get it, and where it runs out. It is one of the oldest branches of philosophy, stretching from Plato's dialogues through Descartes and Hume to the cutting edge of contemporary analytic philosophy.

At first glance, the subject might seem unnecessary. Surely we already know what knowledge is — it is when you are right about something and have good reason to believe it. But this intuitive account, as we shall see, conceals a nest of difficulties. It fails to distinguish different kinds of knowing, it raises deep questions about what 'good reason' really means, and it turns out to be vulnerable to some striking counterexamples. Addressing these difficulties rigorously is the task of epistemology.

This guide walks through the main questions of the field, drawing on the SEP article by Steup and Neta. It is intended as a challenging but accessible introduction, assuming no prior formal training in philosophy. Technical terms are introduced and defined as they appear.

Key Terms at a Glance

Epistemology	The branch of philosophy concerned with the nature, sources, and limits of knowledge.
Cognitive Success	Any achievement of the mind that has positive epistemic value — knowing, understanding, perceiving, remembering, etc.
Justified True Belief (JTB)	The classical analysis of knowledge: to know that <i>p</i> , you must believe <i>p</i> , <i>p</i> must be true, and your belief must be justified.
Gettier Problem	The discovery that JTB is not sufficient for knowledge, because one can have justified true beliefs that are nevertheless not knowledge.
Foundationalism	The view that justified beliefs are structured like a building: some beliefs are 'basic' and others rest upon them.
Coherentism	The view that beliefs are justified by how well they cohere, or fit together, with each other — like a web rather than a building.
Internalism	The view that what justifies a belief is determined solely by factors internal to (i.e., accessible by reflection to) the believer.
Externalism	The view that what justifies a belief can include factors external to the believer's perspective, such as whether the belief was produced by a reliable process.
Scepticism	The philosophical challenge to our claim to have knowledge, often by arguing that we cannot rule out certain radical scenarios.

Section 1: What Counts as Cognitive Success?

Guiding Question: *Is knowledge the only thing epistemology cares about — and what makes any mental achievement count as a success?*

Beyond Knowledge: The Varieties of Cognitive Success

It is tempting to think that epistemology is simply about knowledge. But Steup and Neta begin with a broader framing: epistemology is about cognitive success in general. A cognitive success is any form of mental achievement that has positive epistemic value. Knowledge is one such success, but the list is longer than it first appears.

Consider: you might know a fact, understand a principle, believe something with adequate justification, have a well-calibrated degree of confidence, perceive something clearly, or remember something accurately. Each of these is a different form of cognitive success — and philosophers disagree about which are the most fundamental and how they relate to one another. Some hold that knowledge is primitive and that everything else should be explained in terms of it; others hold that reasons or evidence are the fundamental epistemic currency.

Demands and Values

There is also a distinction worth drawing early. Some epistemic standards are demand-based: to fall below them is to do something impermissible, something epistemically wrong. Others are value-based: to fall below them is simply to be less than optimal, a form of sub-excellence rather than a violation. The analogy in ethics is between what is morally required and what is morally supererogatory (above and beyond the call of duty).

Contemporary epistemologists debate whether epistemic rationality is best understood in terms of demands or values — and whether the two even come apart in practice. A further live debate concerns 'epistemic consequentialism': the view that what makes a belief epistemically permissible is that it promotes the right epistemic goods (typically, having true beliefs and avoiding false ones).

Substantive and Structural Success

A useful distinction introduced in the article is between substantive and structural cognitive success. Substantive success qualifies individual objects: this belief is justified; this procedure is rationally required. Structural success qualifies the relations between objects: these beliefs are mutually consistent; this set of beliefs coheres. Both matter, and the debate about which is more fundamental runs through much of the foundationalism-coherentism debate we will encounter later.

Epistemic Harms and Wrongs

Not all epistemology is concerned with achievement. Steup and Neta note that blocking or obstructing someone's cognitive success constitutes an epistemic harm. Doing so wrongly — through deception, insinuation, indoctrination, or systematic discrediting — constitutes an

epistemic wrong. This connects epistemology directly to ethics and politics, and to the growing literature on epistemic injustice (the wrong done to someone when they are denied recognition as a credible knower, as discussed by Miranda Fricker).

Exam & Essay Tip: The concept of epistemic injustice is a powerful example of how epistemology intersects with ethics and social philosophy. If asked to connect epistemology to broader concerns about justice or identity, this is a rich avenue of argument.

Section 2: What Is Knowledge?

Guiding Question: *Is knowledge simply justified true belief — and if not, what more is needed?*

Three Types of Knowledge

The English word 'knowledge' is ambiguous in ways that other languages make explicit. Philosophers distinguish at least three importantly different uses of the concept, each raising distinct philosophical puzzles.

Knowing Individuals (Knowledge by Acquaintance)

You might know Napoleon in the sense of knowing many facts about him, but you could never have been acquainted with Napoleon, since he died long before you were born. This shows that knowing a person — what Bertrand Russell called knowledge by acquaintance — is distinct from knowing facts. Acquaintance typically requires some perceptual or personal contact with the object known. The precise nature of that contact, and what exactly it demands, remain contested.

Knowing How

Gilbert Ryle famously distinguished knowing how from knowing that. No matter how many facts you know about swimming, it does not follow that you know how to swim. For Ryle, knowing how is a form of practical ability, irreducible to any set of propositional beliefs. This distinction has been challenged: some philosophers, such as Stanley and Williamson, argue that all knowing-how can be analysed as a form of knowing-that. The debate turns on subtle questions about the relationship between practical skill and propositional content.

Knowing Facts (Propositional Knowledge)

By far the most discussed form in analytic epistemology is propositional knowledge — knowing that *p*, where *p* is some proposition or fact. It is this sense of knowledge that the classical JTB analysis attempts to capture.

The classical analysis holds that a subject *S* knows that *p* if and only if: (1) *S* believes that *p*; (2) *p* is true; and (3) *S* is justified in believing that *p*. Each condition appears necessary. You cannot know something you do not believe. You cannot know something false. And if you merely happen to be right by luck, that does not constitute knowledge either — justification is needed to exclude the role of luck.

The Gettier Problem

Classic Case: Henry is driving through a region where, unknown to him, almost all the apparent barns are mere facades. He happens to look at the one real barn in the area and forms the belief 'there is a barn over there.' His belief is true. His visual experience makes it reasonable for him to hold it. And it arises from a normally reliable cognitive process. Yet his belief is true only by luck — had he looked slightly earlier or later, he would have been looking at a facade. Intuitively, Henry does not know there is a barn.

Edmund Gettier showed in a celebrated 1963 paper that JTB is not sufficient for knowledge. Cases like the barn-facades example demonstrate this with force: Henry has a justified true belief, yet clearly lacks knowledge. The 'Gettier problem' asks what fourth condition must be added to JTB to yield a fully adequate analysis of knowledge.

Proposed solutions are numerous. Some add a 'no false lemmas' condition. Others replace the justification condition with a requirement that the belief be produced by a reliable cognitive faculty (reliabilism). Still others abandon the project of adding conditions to JTB altogether, holding instead that knowledge is a primitive concept (Timothy Williamson's influential 'knowledge-first' epistemology). None of these proposals has achieved universal acceptance, and the Gettier problem remains one of the central unresolved puzzles in analytic epistemology.

Exam & Essay Tip: The Gettier problem is one of the most cited results in twentieth-century philosophy. In any essay on the analysis of knowledge, you should be able to state the JTB account, give a Gettier-style counterexample, and evaluate at least one proposed response.

Section 3: What Is Justification?

Guiding Question: *What makes a belief justified — and does justification require that we are aware of our reasons, or can it depend on facts outside our perspective?*

Why Justification Matters

Even when a belief is true, it can fall short of knowledge if it is based on wishful thinking, prejudice, or mere coincidence. Justification is the condition that distinguishes knowledge from lucky guessing. But what exactly is justification? Philosophers disagree deeply about this question, and the debate turns on some fundamental issues about the nature of rationality and the relationship between the mind and the world.

Deontological Justification

One natural starting point is the idea that justification is about epistemic duty. You are justified in believing *p* if and only if you are not obliged to refrain from believing *p* — in other words, if believing *p* is not an epistemic violation. This deontological conception of justification reflects the way philosophers such as Descartes, Locke, and Chisholm thought about the topic.

Two significant objections arise. First, beliefs seem to arise in us involuntarily — we do not choose our beliefs the way we choose our actions. If beliefs are not under our control, it is not clear that we can have epistemic duties regarding them. Second, deontological justification does not seem to ensure that the belief is even likely to be true: a person raised in a thoroughly mistaken culture might violate no duty in believing what they do, yet their beliefs could be systematically false.

Non-Deontological Justification: Evidentialism and Reliabilism

Those who reject the deontological picture tend to define justification in terms of likelihood of truth. Two main positions dominate the contemporary debate.

Evidentialism

Evidentialists hold that what justifies a belief is the evidence the believer possesses. Evidence, on this view, typically consists of perceptual experiences, introspective states, memories, and rational intuitions. If the coffee tastes sweet to you, you have evidence that the coffee is sweet. If you seem to recall having had cereal for breakfast, you have evidence about what you ate. Justification, for the evidentialist, is a function of how well your belief fits the evidence you actually have.

Reliabilism

Reliabilists hold that a belief is justified when it results from a reliable cognitive process — one that tends to produce true beliefs. On this view, the reliability of the process that generates a belief is what confers justification, regardless of whether the believer is aware of that reliability.

A bird-watcher who reliably identifies species correctly on the basis of subtle perceptual cues is justified in her identifications even if she cannot articulate her reasons.

Internalism vs Externalism

The debate between evidentialism and reliabilism reflects a deeper division in epistemology: the internalism-externalism debate. Consider a thought experiment: suppose your brain were removed and placed in a vat, and then stimulated to produce exactly the same experiences you are having now. This 'Brain-in-a-Vat' (BIV) scenario is epistemically indistinguishable from your current situation — from the inside. Internalists hold that if you and your BIV-counterpart are indistinguishable from the inside, you have the same degree of justification. What justifies a belief is determined solely by internally accessible factors: your evidence, your experiences, your reasoning.

Externalists disagree. What matters for justification, they say, is not just internal perspective but also external facts — in particular, whether your beliefs are produced by processes that reliably track the truth. Your BIV counterpart might have the same experiences but, since those experiences are systematically misleading, their beliefs are not justified in the externalist sense.

Internalism in practice: Two students both believe that the Battle of Hastings was in 1066. One has just read it in a reliable textbook; the other was told it by a prankster who happened to give the correct date by accident. Their internal perspectives may be identical, but their epistemic situations are very different — a difference that externalists, but not internalists, can capture.

Exam & Essay Tip: The internalism-externalism debate is one of the most important structuring divisions in contemporary epistemology. When evaluating any theory of justification, ask: does this theory make justification depend only on factors the believer can access by reflection, or on factors outside their perspective?

Section 4: How Is Knowledge Structured?

Guiding Question: *Does justification terminate in bedrock beliefs, or does it spread through a web of mutually supporting beliefs — and which picture is correct?*

The Regress Problem

Our knowledge forms a vast interconnected body, and the question of how it is structured is one of the deepest in epistemology. The starting point is a simple but powerful puzzle: the regress of justification.

Suppose your belief B1 is justified by belief B2. But B2 must itself be justified. So it is justified by B3. And B3 by B4. And so on. This regress appears to have three possible endings: it could go on infinitely (infinetism); it could loop back on itself (circular justification); or it could terminate in a belief that is justified without depending on any further belief (foundationalism). A fourth option is to deny that the regress arises in the way described (coherentism). Each of these positions has sophisticated contemporary defenders, and none is obviously correct.

Foundationalism

Foundationalism holds that our knowledge is structured like a building. There is a foundation of basic beliefs, which are justified in themselves without deriving their justification from any other beliefs. On top of the foundation sits a superstructure of non-basic beliefs, which are justified by their inferential connections to the basic beliefs below them.

The central question for foundationalism is: what makes a belief basic? On one view, basic beliefs are those that are infallible or indubitable — beliefs about one's own current mental states, for instance ('it seems to me that the hat is blue'). On another view, basic beliefs are those justified directly by perceptual experiences, without the need for any further inference.

Privilege Foundationalism: Only beliefs about your own mental states can be basic — because only these are incapable of being false. Beliefs about the external world (e.g., 'that hat is blue') must be inferred from such basic beliefs.

Experiential Foundationalism: Perceptual beliefs (e.g., 'that hat is blue') can be basic, justified directly by the perceptual experience that gave rise to them, without requiring inference from beliefs about how things appear.

A key challenge for foundationalism is the 'J-Question': why should perceptual experience be a source of justification at all? If the answer involves appealing to evidence that such experiences are reliable, foundationalism begins to slide into a form of coherentism. If it appeals to brute necessity, foundationalism may seem arbitrary.

Coherentism

Coherentism rejects the foundationalist metaphor of a building in favour of a web. On this view, no belief is basic; every belief receives its justification from its coherence with the other beliefs in the system. The strength of any given belief depends on the strength of the surrounding web.

There are several varieties of coherentism. Explanatory coherentism holds that a belief is justified when it is part of the best explanation of one's experience. Reliability coherentism holds that a belief is justified when one has justification to think that the process generating it is reliable.

The deepest problem for coherentism is circularity: to say that a belief is justified because it coheres with other beliefs, which cohere with still others, seems to be reasoning in a circle. A coherentist might reply that this circularity is not vicious, since the web of beliefs is being tested as a whole against experience. But critics find this reply unsatisfying.

A further problem for doxastic (belief-based) forms of coherentism is that they seem to make excessive intellectual demands. In ordinary life, we simply perceive that the hat is blue and believe it — we do not first form beliefs about the reliability of our perceptual faculties and then infer that the hat is blue. Coherentism, if taken literally, seems to require a level of epistemic self-consciousness that most people never exercise.

Exam & Essay Tip: The foundationalism-coherentism debate is ideally suited to a 'compare and contrast' essay structure. State the regress problem clearly, show how each view responds to it, and then evaluate using the specific objections covered here — particularly the J-question against foundationalism and the circularity problem against coherentism.

Section 5: Where Does Knowledge Come From?

Guiding Question: *What are the sources from which we derive justified beliefs — and is each of them as reliable as we ordinarily assume?*

Even granting that knowledge is possible, we must ask where it comes from. Epistemologists typically identify five main sources of knowledge and justification: perception, introspection, memory, reason, and testimony. Each raises distinctive puzzles about its reliability and its capacity to generate genuine knowledge.

Perception

Our perceptual faculties — sight, touch, hearing, smell, taste — are the primary means by which we acquire knowledge of the external world. It is important to distinguish between perceiving that *p* (which entails *p* is true) and having a perceptual seeming that *p* (which does not entail truth). Hallucinations are perceptual seemings without perception.

Philosophers divide between direct realists, who hold that in ordinary perception we directly apprehend external objects themselves, and indirect realists, who hold that we directly perceive only sense-data or appearances, from which we infer the existence of external objects. The direct/indirect realism debate connects to broader questions about foundationalism: indirect realists typically take foundational knowledge to be knowledge of sense-data, while direct realists hold that foundational perceptual knowledge can be of external objects.

A deep problem is circularity: to establish that our perceptual faculties are reliable, we seem to need to use those very faculties. Any justification of perception by means of perception appears to reason in a circle — and this is one of the engines driving classical sceptical arguments.

Introspection

Introspection is the capacity to know one's own current mental states: whether one is thirsty, excited, in pain, or in the grip of a belief. It is widely thought that introspection has a special authority that perception lacks — it is very hard to see how I could be wrong about whether I currently feel a throbbing headache. Some philosophers interpret this immunity from error as infallibility: introspective seemings constitute their own success.

But critics note that introspection is not entirely immune from error. Might one confuse mild discomfort for pain? Might one mistake one's belief about what one thinks for one's actual belief? The picture of introspection as a transparent, error-free window onto one's own mind is increasingly contested in contemporary philosophy of mind.

Memory

Memory is the capacity to retain knowledge acquired in the past. But every exercise of memory produces only a seeming to remember that p — and seemings can mislead. The world might, in principle, have sprung into existence five minutes ago, complete with all our apparent memories of a more distant past. This sceptical hypothesis (sometimes called 'five-minute creationism') shows that memorial justification faces philosophical challenges parallel to those faced by perceptual justification.

Reason (A Priori Knowledge)

Some of our knowledge appears to be justified independently of experience — it can be known a priori, through reason alone. Mathematics and logic are the clearest examples: that $2 + 2 = 4$ or that all bachelors are unmarried can be recognised as true without empirical investigation.

Rationalists hold that genuine a priori knowledge of synthetic propositions (propositions that convey information about the world, not merely conceptual truths) is possible. Empiricists typically deny this, holding that all genuine knowledge of the world is empirical, and that a priori truths are

merely analytic (true by definition or by virtue of concepts alone). This debate — one of the oldest in epistemology — turns on subtle questions about the nature of concepts and the limits of what pure reason can establish.

Testimony

An enormous proportion of what we know, we know on the basis of testimony — what others tell us, whether through conversation, books, broadcasts, or the internet. This raises a fundamental question: why is testimony a source of knowledge? An externalist might say that testimony is epistemically valuable when it comes from a reliable source. But the source's reliability is often unknown to the hearer.

One approach, associated with Thomas Reid, holds that there is a natural human disposition to trust testimony and to be trusted, and that this disposition is itself a rational default. Another approach requires a track record of success before testimony is credited. A third holds that trust in testimony is a necessary truth, knowable a priori. The epistemology of testimony connects directly to social epistemology — the study of how knowledge is produced, transmitted, and distorted in communities.

Exam & Essay Tip: On the topic of sources of knowledge, a strong answer will not merely list them but identify what is philosophically distinctive about each. The most productive comparisons are: perception vs introspection (fallibility vs immunity to error), and memory vs testimony (both transmit rather than generate knowledge). The a priori is especially rich territory given the rationalism-empiricism debate.

Section 6: Can We Know Anything at All?

Guiding Question: *Can a philosopher ever conclusively demonstrate that we have no knowledge of the external world — and how should we respond?*

The Challenge of Scepticism

Scepticism is the philosophical position (or challenge) that our pre-theoretical picture of ourselves as successful knowers is systematically mistaken. It comes in two main forms. General scepticism challenges the possibility of any knowledge whatsoever. Selective scepticism targets a particular domain — the external world, the past, other minds, the future — while conceding that we know other things.

Selective scepticism typically proceeds by constructing a sceptical hypothesis: a scenario that is indistinguishable, from the subject's perspective, from the ordinary situation, but in which the

subject has no knowledge. The most famous sceptical hypotheses in contemporary epistemology are the brain-in-a-vat (BIV) scenario and Descartes' evil demon. If you cannot rule out that you are a BIV being fed artificial experiences, then you cannot know that you have hands, or that there is an external world at all.

The Brain-in-a-Vat Closure Argument

The BIV Argument (BKCA): (C1) I do not know that I am not a brain in a vat. (C2) If I do not know that I am not a BIV, then I do not know that I have hands. Therefore: (C3) I do not know that I have hands.

Both premises appear compelling. (C1) seems true because everything appears identical whether I am a BIV or not; my experiences provide no evidence that distinguishes the two cases. (C2) seems true because of knowledge closure: if I know that having hands entails not being a (handless) BIV, then knowing that I have hands should require knowing that I am not a BIV. Yet the conclusion — that I do not know I have hands — strikes nearly everyone as plainly false.

This puts us in the uncomfortable position of having to reject one of two apparently plausible premises. Which should we reject, and on what grounds?

Responses to Scepticism

The Relevant Alternatives Response

One response accepts premise (C2) but denies that the BIV scenario is a 'relevant' alternative to having hands. On this view, you know that you have hands because you can discriminate between having hands and all relevant alternatives (stumps, prosthetics, etc.) — even if you cannot discriminate between having hands and the BIV scenario. The BIV scenario is too far-fetched to be relevant. The problem is that this response needs an independent account of what makes an alternative relevant, which has proven difficult to provide.

The Moorean Response

G. E. Moore suggested we should simply run the argument backwards. If premise (C2) is true and the conclusion is false, then premise (C1) must be false — I do know that I am not a BIV. The argument's premises are less plausible than the denial of its conclusion. This 'Moorean' response has a commonsense appeal, but it is widely criticised for failing to explain how we can know that we are not BIVs. Merely asserting that we know is not the same as explaining how such knowledge is possible.

Contextualism

Contextualists argue that the meaning of 'knows' varies with context. In ordinary contexts, the standards for knowledge are modest enough that I count as knowing I have hands. But when the BIV hypothesis is explicitly raised in conversation, the standards are raised dramatically, and I no longer count as knowing even ordinary things. On this view, there is no genuine contradiction between saying (in ordinary contexts) 'I know I have hands' and saying (in the sceptical philosophical context) 'I do not know that I am not a BIV.'

Contextualism is philosophically sophisticated but has attracted persistent criticism. It appears to make the truth of knowledge attributions vary with conversational context in a way that many find counterintuitive — and it does not explain how we could ever come to know that we are not BIVs, even when the standards are at their most modest.

Beyond the closure argument, sceptics deploy further arguments: the underdetermination argument (our evidence is equally consistent with the external world hypothesis and the BIV hypothesis, so we are not justified in believing one over the other), the defeasibility argument (any knowledge we have can be defeated by evidence that we are BIVs), and the epistemic possibility argument (if it is possible that we are BIVs, then we cannot know that we have hands). Each argument targets a different feature of the concept of knowledge and requires a distinct response.

Exam & Essay Tip: Scepticism essays reward a structured approach: state the sceptical hypothesis; reconstruct the argument in numbered premise form; identify which premise is the target of each response; evaluate the cost of rejecting that premise. The strongest answers consider whether each response merely denies a premise or actually explains how knowledge is possible despite the sceptical challenge.

Conclusion: Where Does Epistemology Leave Us?

Epistemology has been described, not altogether unfairly, as a discipline that begins by questioning what everyone knows and ends without having answered the question. But this caricature misses the genuine philosophical progress the field has made. We now understand far more clearly what is at stake in questions about the nature of knowledge, the structure of justification, the sources of belief, and the limits of what we can claim to know. We have sharper tools — the JTB analysis, the Gettier problem, the internalism-externalism distinction, the regress argument, the BIV hypothesis — for probing these questions with precision.

What epistemology reveals, above all, is that the pre-philosophical concept of knowledge is richer, more fragile, and more philosophically loaded than it first appears. Unpacking it carefully is not mere pedantry — it is essential to understanding what rational inquiry amounts to, and what we owe each other as epistemic agents in a world of shared and contested knowledge.

Questions for Further Reflection

The following questions are designed for independent work, discussion, or essay preparation:

- Does the distinction between knowing-how and knowing-that successfully carve nature at its joints? Can you think of a case where the distinction seems to break down?
- Is the Gettier problem a decisive refutation of the JTB analysis, or can the analysis be repaired? Evaluate one proposed repair and identify its strengths and weaknesses.
- Can evidentialism and reliabilism be reconciled — or does accepting one require rejecting the other? What would a hybrid theory look like?
- The internalist holds that justification is always accessible on reflection. Is this claim plausible? What does it imply about the epistemic situation of animals and young children?
- Does the foundationalism-coherentism debate have a victor — or does each position collapse into the other under sustained pressure?
- Is perceptual knowledge possible given that perception is fallible? How does the fallibility of perception bear on the foundationalist's project?
- Is the Moorean response to scepticism ultimately question-begging? Is there a satisfying account of how we can know that we are not brains in vats?
- Does contextualism dissolve the sceptical problem or merely relocate it? Can a contextualist explain what ordinary knowledge consists in, or only explain the meaning of 'knows'?

Key Thinkers at a Glance

Plato (428–348 BCE)	Explored the nature of knowledge in the <i>Meno</i> and <i>Theaetetus</i> ; distinguished knowledge from true opinion.
René Descartes (1596–1650)	Used the evil demon hypothesis to motivate scepticism; sought to rebuild knowledge on indubitable foundations.
John Locke (1632–1704)	Empiricist; argued all knowledge derives ultimately from sense experience and reflection.
David Hume (1711–1776)	Radical empiricist and sceptic; questioned the justification of induction and causal reasoning.

Immanuel Kant (1724–1804)	Argued that the mind actively structures experience; distinguished analytic from synthetic a priori knowledge.
Bertrand Russell (1872–1970)	Distinguished knowledge by acquaintance from knowledge by description; sought logical foundations for mathematics.
Gilbert Ryle (1900–1976)	Distinguished knowing how from knowing that; argued many philosophical puzzles arise from category mistakes.
Edmund Gettier (1927–2019)	Published a three-page paper in 1963 that overturned decades of orthodoxy by showing JTB is insufficient for knowledge.
Alvin Goldman (b. 1938)	Developed process reliabilism; a major figure in both formal and social epistemology.
Timothy Williamson (b. 1955)	Argues knowledge is primitive and unanalysable; proposed the 'knowledge-first' epistemology.
Miranda Fricker (b. 1966)	Developed the concept of epistemic injustice; bridged epistemology with ethics and political philosophy.

Suggestions for Further Reading

Arranged roughly from most to least accessible for Sixth Form students:

- (*) Bertrand Russell, *The Problems of Philosophy* (1912) — clear and readable; chapters 1 and 13 are especially relevant. Free online.
- (*) Nigel Warburton, *Philosophy: The Basics* (any edition), Chapter 3 — the most accessible introduction to epistemology in print.
- (*) Jonathan Dancy, *An Introduction to Contemporary Epistemology* (1985) — the standard undergraduate primer; slightly technical but rewarding.
- Edmund Gettier, 'Is Justified True Belief Knowledge?' (1963), *Analysis* 23(6) — three pages long; one of the most cited philosophy papers of the twentieth century. Free online.
- René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy* (1641), *Meditations* 1 and 2 — the original sceptical thought experiment, including the evil demon. Free online.
- Miranda Fricker, *Epistemic Injustice* (2007), Chapter 1 — accessible introduction to testimonial injustice.

- Timothy Williamson, *Knowledge and Its Limits* (2002), Chapter 1 — demanding but important; introduces the knowledge-first approach.
- Matthias Steup and Ram Neta, 'Epistemology', *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Fall 2025 Edition) — the primary source for this guide. Available free at plato.stanford.edu.

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